Roxburgh Ramble 24 hr Rogaine

Organiser's observations

www.rogaine.org.nz

The event seemed to proceed without hiccups. We were lucky with the weather, with the fog staying clear of the tops for most of the time and the light cloud cover keeping people cool without stopping too much of the moon. The night either side of the event was much worse; the woolshed was under fog on the Sunday night after that magnificent meal and the sunny prize giving, and it even rained for a while.

The area was chosen because it is the nearest land to Christchurch where an A3 map could be found with uninterrupted interesting country, a modest number of landowners, and the ability to travel almost anywhere. In retrospect, the weather was a bigger risk than I had imagined, with regular fogs and cold winds.

All the checkpoints were visited, and a wide range of route choices was made by the teams. Most teams avoided the Lake Onslow watershed in the night, with about a third choosing the long ridge system down the eastern side in a variety of configurations.

Although only 40 teams competed, there was very strong competition in most classes. The skill and strength of Keith Murray and Aidan Craig clearly showed, with their large winning margin. Their chosen course had them in the south-west corner in the night, where more handrails and better visibility no doubt aided their navigation.

The map proved to be the usual hassle, obtaining a suitable scan in A3 size with good resolution, and getting the commercially printed colours to match my own. Trying to educate commercial printers on the importance of resolution and detail on maps is also a challenge, when their experience is geared to glossy advertising.

Results were processed quickly thanks to the excellent team of Jac and Leslie Woudberg, Frank Dennis, Phil Bones, Michael Smithson, and a competitor Paul Dale. The first printout was done 12 minutes after the last finishers.

The catering was a new experience for the Roxburgh Lions. Although they regularly cater for large numbers, they have never had a "progressive" meal before, with unpredictable numbers and timings. They did superbly, and their final lunchtime banquet was a magnificent feast. I hope you all enjoyed it as much as I did.

With the help of Jac, Leslie, Frank, and Russell, over half the checkpoints were retrieved on the Sunday afternoon, with the balance being picked up on Monday.

As usual, the Landowners were the most crucial component of the event. It is a big ask for them to allow an unknown number of unknown people to travel on unknown routes across any part of their farm in an unknown sport. When they actually see the event and the enthusiasm of the competitors they are usually very supportive. The contribution made by all the competitors in talking to the farmers they met, and the care they take with stock and fences, is an important ingredient in this. The goodwill of the landowners and others in the district spreads to adjacent areas, and makes future events easier to get approval for.

Pete Squires